Preference, Restriction, Allergy or Prescribed Instruction? A One-Page Sheet for What You Write About Your Wife

Seventeen categories and terms in one plain line each, and what to note under each.

“She doesn't like fish” and “she has a nut allergy” are both about food. One is your wife's preference and the other is something a clinician told you, and a new caregiver should be able to tell them apart at a glance. This sheet gives each kind of note a name and says what to write down for it.

The sorting is for your notes. It isn't for deciding what she can eat or do. When you can't place something, it goes to the care team as a question.

Four kinds of note, and a fifth for the unsure ones

Preference

Something she likes, dislikes or chooses: how she takes her tea, when she gets up, the name she goes by. In a nursing home, Medicare's guide for residents says, staff must recognize and respect a resident's preferences when giving care. [1]

WRITE DOWN Her own words, and whether she told you or you filled it in.

Restriction

On this sheet, something a doctor, nurse or dietitian has told you she should avoid or limit. If you can't say who told you, it goes under Needs checking.

WRITE DOWN What was said, who said it and when. Copy it from the written instructions if you have them.

Allergy

A medical matter, not a dislike. MedlinePlus describes a food allergy as an abnormal immune system reaction to certain foods, and says a food intolerance is different. [2]

WRITE DOWN What you were told, and by whom. Whether it's an allergy or an intolerance is for her clinicians to say.

Prescribed instruction

Anything a clinician has directed about her care, such as a diet. The written copy is the instruction. Your page doesn't restate it or change it.

WRITE DOWN That it exists, who gave it, and where the written copy is.

Needs checking

Where a note goes when you can't tell whether it is her preference or a clinician's instruction. It is a question for the care team, and it isn't settled on this sheet.

WRITE DOWN The note as it stands, and who you'll ask.

The headings of an About Me page

How I like to be addressed

The name she wants new caregivers to use. The Alzheimer's Association's Personal Facts and Insights form asks for a preferred name as well as the person's name. [3]

WRITE DOWN The name, and any she'd rather not hear.

Morning and evening routines

How her day starts and ends. The same form asks for wake-up time, bedtime, naps and any established routines. [3]

WRITE DOWN The times, the order of things, and what she does first.

Food preferences, and restrictions kept separately

What she likes and dislikes on one list, what clinicians have instructed on another. The form gives special dietary needs, food allergies, favorite foods and strong dislikes each their own line. [3]

WRITE DOWN Two lists, never merged.

Activities and relationships

What she enjoys and who matters to her. A nursing home resident, Medicare's guide says, has the right to take part in activities that interest her. [1]

WRITE DOWN The activity or the person, and any help she'd need to take part. Taking part stays her choice.

Communication preferences

How she likes to be spoken with. The form asks which communication styles work best, whether the person is hard of hearing, and whether she needs extra time to respond. [3]

WRITE DOWN What works, in a line she'd agree with.

Cultural or religious preferences

Observances, customs or matters of faith that she has raised herself. A workbook from The Conversation Project gives "My faith is very important to me" as an example of something to tell a health care team. [4]

WRITE DOWN Only what she has volunteered, in her words.

What helps me feel comfortable

What settles her in an unfamiliar place. The form asks "What is calming?" and what, if anything, is irritating or upsetting. [3]

WRITE DOWN The object, the habit or the words that help.

Source and review date

Who each piece came from and when it was last checked with her. The form ends with "Completed by" and "Date completed" lines, and the workbook suggests revisiting answers because preferences often change. [3] [4]

WRITE DOWN Her account or yours, the date, and when you'll look at it again.

Words you may hear from the new team

Person-centered planning

The Administration for Community Living's name for a way of selecting and organizing the services and supports a person may need to live in the community, directed by the person who receives them. [5]

WRITE DOWN Whether she has been asked directly, and what she said.

Care plan

In a nursing home, a strategy for how staff will help a resident on a daily basis. Medicare's guide says it must describe how the home will meet her needs and preferences. [6] [1]

WRITE DOWN Whether one exists yet, and who to ask about her preferences being in it.

Resident assessment

A nursing home's gathering of information about a resident's health and physical condition. The National Consumer Voice says it also examines her habits, activities and relationships, and typically involves the resident and family members along with the staff. [6]

WRITE DOWN Whether one is planned, and who from the family will take part.

CNA, LVN, HHA

Training abbreviations: certified nursing assistant, licensed vocational nurse, home health aide. In nursing homes, the Consumer Voice notes, the CNAs do the direct hands-on work with residents. [7] [6]

WRITE DOWN The names of the people who are with her day to day.

What this sheet doesn't do

It names categories. It doesn't tell you which one a particular note about your wife belongs in when that takes clinical knowledge, and it doesn't turn any preference into an instruction. The kinds of note and the About Me headings are the Family Care Roadmap's own. The lines with a number come from the sources below, some of which were written about nursing homes or for families living with dementia; nothing here assumes anything about her health or where she'll be cared for.

Ready for the next step?

You can tell her preferences from the instructions her clinicians gave, and you know what to note for each. The care interview covers the same areas in plain language: it asks about her preferences across every part of the day, alongside her care needs and the support around her, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Your guide to living in a nursing home (CMS Product No. 12217)
2. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine), Food Allergy
3. Alzheimer's Association, Personal Facts and Insights (form)
4. The Conversation Project (Institute for Healthcare Improvement) and Ariadne Labs, What Matters to Me: A Workbook for Better Health Care
5. Administration for Community Living, Person-Centered Planning
6. National Consumer Voice for Quality Long-Term Care, Family Involvement in Nursing Homes (fact sheet)
7. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hiring In-Home Help